


## Warning: You Must Be Fully Prepared for an Online Exam

- **Practice:** Candidates are responsible for being fully prepared, because each session uses the time of volunteer examiners and a time slot that another candidate could have used. Your practice test scores must be consistently above 85%.
- **Knowledge of the Material:** You should be able to complete the exam within 15 minutes. Most questions address short, simple concepts. Each candidate is allocated 20 minutes, from setup to finish.
- **Practice Sites:** HamStudy.org, a free site with study tips, or ARRL Exam Review for Ham Radio™, a free site from the national association for amateur radio.
- **One Exam per Session:** Because online exams are administered to one candidate at a time, you may take only **one** exam per session unless additional exams have been arranged with the exam team by email in advance. You must be scoring passing grades on practice tests for every exam you plan to take.
- **Certificate of Successful Completion of Examination (CSCE):** When you pass any element, the Exam Manager sends you a CSCE that includes your digital signature. Keep it for your records.

## FCC Universal Licensing System (ULS)

- **FCC Registration Number (FRN):** If you do not have an FRN, obtain one before booking from the FCC's Registration page by selecting "Register for an FRN." The FRN identifies you in all transactions with the FCC. A Social Security number is required to apply. An FCC instructional video, https://www.fcc.gov/rofrn, explains each step.
- **Email Address:** "Applicants are strongly encouraged to provide an email address on their license application(s), which will trigger the electronic issuance of an official copy of their license(s) to the email provided upon application grant." – FCC statement
- **Privacy Information:** When a license is issued, the licensee's name and address become public information. A mailing address, such as a PO Box, is acceptable. Details: https://www.arrl.org/fcc-licensee-privacy. Social Security numbers, phone numbers and email addresses are never published.
- **Basic Qualification Question:** Applicants must answer the FCC basic qualification question (the felony question). An applicant who answers **yes** must submit the required documentation directly to the FCC within 14 days, as described at https://www.arrl.org/fcc-qualification-question. Do not send any information or documents to the Volunteer Examiner team or the VEC.

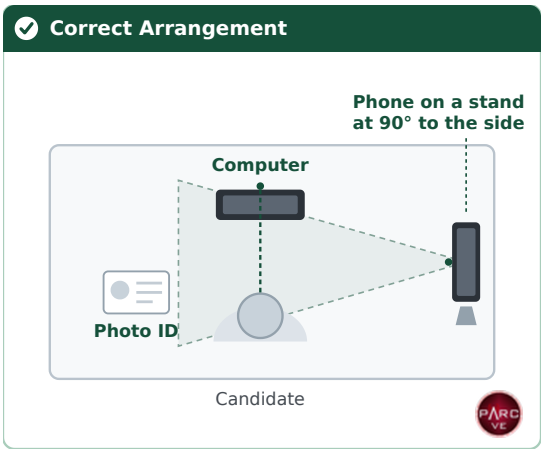
- **FCC Enforcement Advisory:** “Amateur and Personal Radio Services Licensees and Operators may not use radio equipment to commit or facilitate criminal acts.” “Individuals using radios in the Amateur or Personal Radio Services in this manner may be subject to severe penalties, including significant fines, seizure of the offending equipment, and, in some cases, criminal prosecution.” The complete advisory is published by the Federal Communications Commission as a Public Notice.

## What You Need to Prepare

- **Booking and Exam Fee:** First, book a time on the schedule page. The non-refundable $15 exam fee is paid as part of booking; there is no separate payment step. PayPal is used only for donations, never for exam fees. The fee is forwarded to the ARRL VEC with your exam scores and application.
- **Exam Application:** Second, within 48 hours of booking, the exam team emails you a **link** to your exam session, where you complete the exam application (an electronic VEC Form 605). Complete it as soon as it arrives.
- **Photo Identification:** Show one photo ID on camera to the VE team. Adults must show an unexpired state-issued driver’s license, state ID card or U.S. passport. A candidate under 18 may show one of these, or may show one document from the site’s identification list, such as a school ID or birth certificate, while a parent or legal guardian presents their own photo ID. Identification must be the physical document. Digital IDs and copies are not accepted.
- **Parental Consent:** For a candidate age 13 or under, a parent must complete the COPPA Parental Consent Form and email it to the address on the form.
- **Parent in the Room:** For a candidate under age 13, a parent remains in the room during the exam.

### Prepare Your Exam Room

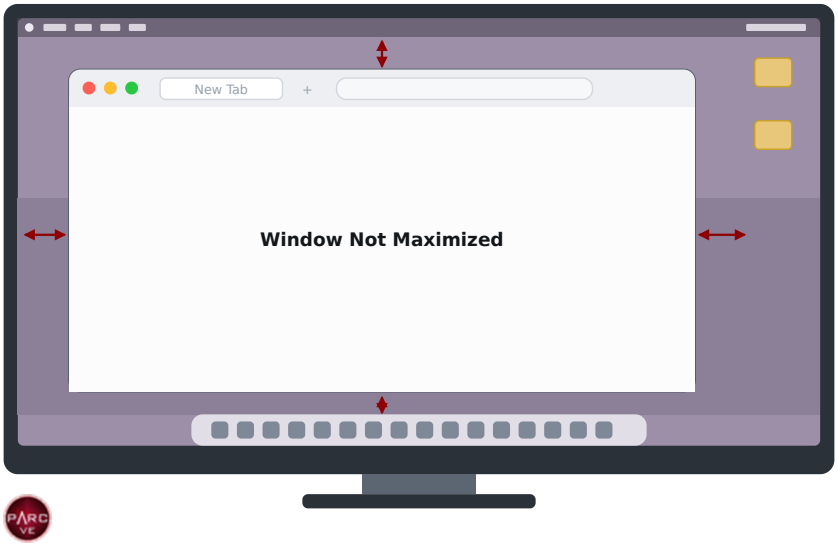
- Clear the exam room of any materials that could aid in taking the exam, such as papers, notes, posters, additional screens, calculators and watches. A bathroom is often a suitable location. Vehicles, outdoor locations and public spaces are not permitted; a private library room is acceptable. Televisions must be unplugged or covered.
- Sit at a table or other flat, sturdy surface, so that the computer and phone stay firmly in place. Do not sit on a bed or on a movable chair.
- Clear the exam table of **all** items within reach or view that could raise suspicion, such as papers, sticky notes, electronic items, monitors, headphones, food and drinks, and anything else not needed for the exam (see the picture).
- Virtual backgrounds and background effects are not permitted; the examiners must see the entire room.
- Instruct household members not to enter the room during the exam. If anyone enters, the exam must be voided.
- No other persons or animals are permitted in the exam room or nearby, except a service dog.




*Correct arrangement: one computer, the phone on a stand at 90 degrees to the side, and your photo ID.*

## Prepare Your Computer

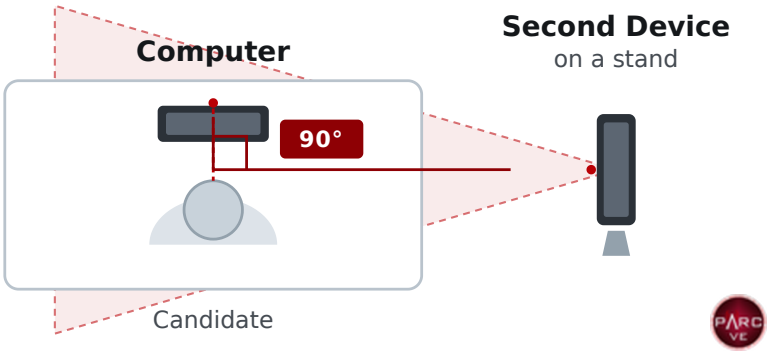
- A working Windows 10 (or later) or Mac laptop or desktop computer is required, with a webcam facing you directly (on a laptop, the built-in camera), a microphone, and reliable internet service. VPNs and phone hotspots are not permitted.
- Tablets, iPads, Chromebooks and Linux computers **cannot** be used; they cannot run the exam.
- Remove **all** audio devices, headphones, earbuds, smartwatches, **hats**, Bluetooth mice, additional monitors and keyboards, and anything else that could be considered suspicious or is not needed for the exam.
- Disable chat, alerts, Bluetooth devices, virtual screens, VPNs and pop-up applications.
- **No external mouse or keyboard** may be connected to a laptop. Press the A, B, C or D key to answer a question and advance to the next one. The **left and right arrow keys** move back and forward through the questions.
- **Test your browser.** Make sure the window is **not** full screen and is sized as shown in the picture below, then close it.
- **Use the calculator built into ExamTools.** Do not open a separate calculator application, and do not keep a physical calculator in the room.
- Install Zoom on both the computer and the phone, and test both on the Zoom test page. Zoom must run as an **application**, not in a browser.
- At least 45 minutes before your exam, the exam team emails you a link to join Zoom on **both** the computer and the phone.
- **Sign out** of Zoom on both devices before joining. When Zoom asks for a name, type your name followed by “computer” or “phone.” A device cannot be renamed in the waiting room.
- Before the day of the exam, practice the **Share Screen** option in Zoom, for example in a meeting with a friend.
- Practice minimizing the **Zoom video windows** so that they do not cover the browser.




*The browser window may be large, but the desktop must remain visible on every side.*

### Prepare Your Smartphone

- An internet-connected phone with a built-in camera is required.
- The phone must be charged or connected to power.
- **Do not touch the phone** when the exam team admits it to the session. **Wait for instructions.** The team must disconnect the phone's audio to prevent feedback.
- "Auto-join Audio" must be **off**. "Do Not Disturb" must be **on**.
- Learn how to **switch** from the front (selfie) camera to the rear camera, and how to hold the phone horizontally. The camera is used to scan the room, the computer and your hands, and then to observe you during the session.
- Prepare a **stand** that holds the phone **horizontally**, with a **side view** of the computer, during the exam.




*Place the phone on a stand directly to your left or right, not behind you, with a view of your hands, the keyboard and the screen.*

## Exam Day Procedures

### Be Ready 45 Minutes Before the Exam

- **Review all rules** and prepare the exam area, computer and phone, particularly the rules on watches, hats, and not touching the phone when it joins.
- **Have your photo ID ready.** No other papers are needed: no PIN and no FRN.

- **Name the computer and the phone** as you join, while signed out of Zoom, so that the Exam Manager can tell them apart. For example: “Jane Doe computer” and “Jane Doe phone.”
- **Join the Zoom waiting room** on both the computer and the phone, 45 minutes early, using the emailed link. If the email has not arrived, check the spam folder.
- **Quit all applications** except Zoom.
- **Do not touch the phone** after it is admitted to the session, until the team has disconnected its audio.
- **Follow directions, and do not interrupt the examiner.** Speaking causes Zoom to mute the examiner, and the instructions will be missed.